WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

CAMEROON

Africa

Information current as of October 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Douala	Economic capital and principal seaport, serving landlocked CEMAC neighbours; the country's commercial centre and site of a port economic zone	Trade, logistics, manufacturing, financial services
Yaoundé	Political capital and seat of government; headquarters of the Bank of Central African States (BEAC)	Administration, construction, services
Kribi deep-sea port and Kribi Port Industrial Zone	Fast-growing regional hub: container throughput rose 82% to 750,000 TEUs in the first year of the second terminal, alongside a planned €795 million industrial zone	Port logistics, transshipment, agro-industry, metallurgy, construction materials
Southern iron ore belt (Kribi-Lobé, Bipindi-Grand Zambi, Mbalam)	Three iron ore projects with planned investment of CFA1,748 billion under the 2026–2030 mining strategy, linked to Kribi port	Mining, rail, mining services, power
Sanaga River / Nachtigal (Centre)	Site of the 420 MW Nachtigal hydropower plant, fully online since March 2025 and generating about 3,000 GWh a year	Hydropower, transmission, energy-intensive industry
Chad–Cameroon pipeline corridor	1,070 km pipeline, about 890 km of it in Cameroon, carrying Chadian crude to an offshore terminal near Kribi; Cameroon is the transit gateway for landlocked neighbours	Energy transit, logistics, oilfield services
Centre, South, West and Littoral regions	Stable economic core and heartland of cocoa, coffee and timber production	Agriculture, agro-processing, timber, consumer goods

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Investment Promotion Agency (API), the national one-stop shop, which aims to approve applications within 10 days (down from about 25) and is digitalising its services
- Ordinance No. 2025/002 of 18 July 2025, replacing the 2013 investment law with graduated tax credits, accelerated depreciation, customs facilities and targeted incentives for economic-zone and PPP projects; 36 investment conventions were signed in its first months
- Economic zones, including the port zones of Douala and Kribi and the new Kribi Port Industrial Zone, offering tax and customs exemptions for qualifying projects

- CFA franc issued by the BEAC and pegged to the euro at 655.957; capital and profits may be repatriated under CEMAC exchange rules, with BEAC authorisation required for foreign-exchange transactions above CFA50 million
- OHADA harmonised business law with recourse to the Common Court of Justice and Arbitration (CCJA), plus ICSID and New York Convention membership; up to 100% foreign ownership permitted outside defence and national security
- Sector entry through partnership with the National Hydrocarbons Corporation (SNH) in oil and gas, mining permits for minerals, and public-private partnerships in power and infrastructure, following the Nachtigal model

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Cameroon in October 2026 offers the largest and most diversified economy in Central Africa, with steady growth and low inflation. GDP grew 3.5% in 2025, matching 2024, with services remaining strong, and the IMF expects growth to rise towards 4.6% by 2031 as mining diversification develops. Average inflation eased to 2.6% in the year to August 2026, allowing the BEAC to cut its policy rates in June 2026 and hold its main rate at 4.5% in September. Cameroon became Central Africa's largest FDI recipient in 2025, attracting $599 million. A new investment incentive regime under Ordinance No. 2025/002 has already produced 36 investment conventions worth about CFA7 trillion in projected investment, while Kribi port's container throughput rose 82% to 750,000 TEUs in the second terminal's first year.

Cameroon's main structural task is to replace declining oil output with new sources of growth and revenue: oil GDP fell 7.2% in 2025, oil still accounts for nearly half of exports, and the IMF rates the country at high risk of debt distress even though public debt is a moderate 40.3% of GDP and projected to decline. The policy response is well defined. Three iron ore projects worth CFA1,748 billion are planned for 2026–2030, the 420 MW Nachtigal hydropower plant has added clean baseload power, and the Kribi Port Industrial Zone, backed by the African Development Bank, the EU's Global Gateway and the IFC, targets agro-industry, metallurgy and manufacturing. The government is prioritising concessional financing and fuel-subsidy reform, and maintains close engagement with the IMF. For investors, the transition creates openings in mining services, power transmission, logistics and agro-processing.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Declining oil production	Oil GDP fell 7.2% in 2025 and hydrocarbon output continues to ease, narrowing a source of exports and revenue	Non-oil growth of 3.9% and a large iron ore, power and agro-processing pipeline create diversification opportunities for new investors
Public finances and debt	The IMF rates Cameroon at high risk of debt distress, and fuel subsidies widened the deficit to 2.1% of GDP in 2025; debt is 40.3% of GDP and projected to fall	Structure projects with DFI co-finance and political-risk cover, and agree clear payment terms for public-sector contracts
CEMAC foreign-exchange procedures	Transactions above CFA50 million need BEAC authorisation, and transfers can take over 60 days in practice	Build transfer timelines into treasury planning and use domiciled local bank accounts; the euro peg provides currency stability
Regional security in the Northwest, Southwest and Far North	Armed groups remain active in parts of the Northwest and Far North, while violence has declined in the Southwest	Locate operations in the stable Centre, South, West and Littoral regions, where most economic activity is concentrated, and use professional security advice
Governance and FATF increased monitoring	Cameroon has been on the FATF list of jurisdictions under increased monitoring since June 2023 and ranked 140 of 180 in the 2024 Corruption Perceptions Index	Apply enhanced due diligence and anti-corruption controls, and use OHADA, CCJA and ICSID arbitration in contracts; completing the FATF action plan would ease banking relationships
Political succession	President Biya, 93, has led Cameroon since 1982; his extended stay abroad from June 2026 has raised succession	Institutional and CEMAC frameworks provide continuity; include leadership-transition scenarios in planning and

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	questions, while presidential decrees continue to be issued	maintain broad government relationships
Power transmission and logistics bottlenecks	Slow expansion of transmission capacity is weighing on growth, and Kribi-Lobé iron ore exports have been deferred to July 2027	Captive power and transmission projects are investable opportunities; Kribi port is expanding towards 1–1.2 million TEUs of capacity by 2028

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Cameroon's risk profile is that of a diversified, stable-currency economy managing a gradual transition away from oil. The euro peg, inflation of 2.6% and moderate debt of around 40% of GDP give a predictable macroeconomic base, and continued IMF engagement supports fiscal discipline. The main considerations for investors are practical: CEMAC exchange procedures that lengthen transfer times, the IMF's high debt-distress rating and its implications for public-sector payment terms, FATF increased monitoring, and security in parts of the Northwest and Far North, all of which can be managed through treasury planning, DFI partnership, enhanced due diligence and careful site selection in the stable economic core. Political succession is a genuine question given the President's age and extended absence from public view in 2026, and investors should include transition scenarios in their planning. The upside is substantial: Kribi's rapid growth, a new investment incentive regime and a multi-billion-dollar mining and power pipeline position Cameroon as Central Africa's leading gateway.

MARKET ACCESS

Cameroon is the largest economy in the Economic and Monetary Community of Central Africa (CEMAC), a six-country monetary union of more than 50 million consumers sharing the CFA franc, and its ports at Douala and Kribi are the natural gateway for landlocked Chad and the Central African Republic. It is a WTO member and was chosen to host the WTO Ministerial Conference in Yaoundé in March 2026, is a signatory of the African Continental Free Trade Area, and is the only Central African state to have ratified an Economic Partnership Agreement with the EU, with a matching UK–Cameroon EPA in force since 1 January 2021. Oil (48.6%), cocoa (27.1%) and timber (10.2%) led exports in 2024, with the Netherlands, China, India, Italy and France the main markets. Kribi's transshipment role, serving ports from Nigeria to Angola, and the Chad–Cameroon pipeline extend Cameroon's reach across the Gulf of Guinea.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Presidency of the Republic (President Paul Biya)	Ultimate decision-making authority; signs the decrees that approve major financing agreements and senior appointments	Primary reference point for strategic direction and approval of large projects
Investment Promotion Agency (API)	National one-stop shop administering incentives and investment conventions under Ordinance No. 2025/002	Standard first point of contact for market entry and incentive negotiation
Bank of Central African States (BEAC)	Regional central bank in Yaoundé; sets monetary policy and authorises large foreign-exchange transactions	Relevant for currency, repatriation and banking-sector matters
Ministry of Economy, Planning and Regional Development (MINEPAT)	Signs external financing agreements and coordinates major public investment projects	Key counterpart for PPPs and DFI-backed infrastructure
National Hydrocarbons Corporation (SNH)	State oil and gas company and partner in hydrocarbon and gas-supply arrangements	Essential partner for any energy-sector engagement
Port Authority of Kribi (PAK)	Manages Kribi deep-sea port and leads the €795 million Kribi Port Industrial Zone with private partners	Gateway for logistics, industrial and mining-export investment
BVMAC and COSUMAF	CEMAC regional stock exchange, formed	Relevant for capital raising and regional

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
	in 2019 from the merger of the Douala Stock Exchange, and its capital-markets regulator	financial-services investment

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

GECAM, Cameroon's leading employers' association, is the main domestic business network and hosts an arbitration centre in Douala. The Investment Promotion Agency runs investor awareness workshops on the new incentive regime and supports sector outreach. Development finance institutions are central to the deal environment: the IFC, MIGA, Africa50 and EDF partnered on Nachtigal, while the African Development Bank, the EU's Global Gateway programme and the IFC are expected to finance the first phase of the Kribi Port Industrial Zone. Port operators and international shipping and logistics groups at Kribi and Douala, together with major oil, mining and agribusiness companies, are valuable sources of practical market intelligence.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Cameroon suits investors seeking a long-term position in Central Africa's largest and most diversified economy: logistics, port and industrial investors building on Kribi's growth and the new industrial zone; agro-processing and timber investors adding value to cocoa, coffee and wood exports; mining-services, rail and power investors supporting the iron ore pipeline; and energy investors pursuing independent power and transmission projects on the Nachtigal model. Infrastructure funds and investors working alongside development finance institutions are particularly well placed, and all investors should plan for CEMAC exchange procedures and apply robust due diligence.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage the Investment Promotion Agency on the new incentive regime
Open dialogue with the API to understand eligibility, tax credits and convention terms under Ordinance No. 2025/002.

STEP 2: Assess Kribi port and industrial zone opportunities
Engage the Port Authority of Kribi and its private partners on sites, sector clusters and timelines in the Kribi Port Industrial Zone.

STEP 3: Plan treasury and repatriation under CEMAC rules
Take early banking and legal advice on BEAC authorisations, domiciled accounts and realistic transfer timelines.

STEP 4: Partner with development finance institutions
Explore co-financing and political-risk cover with the IFC, MIGA, the African Development Bank and EU Global Gateway, as used on Nachtigal and Kribi.

STEP 5: Build robust due diligence and scenario planning
Apply enhanced compliance checks, select sites in the stable economic core and include leadership-transition scenarios in planning.